

1837–1855

DEMURE DAY DRESSES

From the late 1830s dresses expanded slowly but surely to ever wider proportions, enveloping the legs and ankles completely. Lower shoulder lines and tighter sleeves restricted the range of upper body movement, as did square shawls folded diagonally and draped around shoulders. Corsets, and often bodices, were stiffened with whalebone and had a long front busk pushing down on the embonpoint (plumpness of the stomach), creating a narrow waist. Full skirts, organ-pleated into the waist, were supported on multiple layers of petticoats, at least one of which was stiffened with *crin*, (from the French for horsehair). Dress skirts began to feature tiers and, by the early 1850s, were embellished with trimmings. The desired look, as shown in these fashion plates from France and England, was meek and submissive. Accessories such as beadwork bags, purses, and parasols were pretty and feminine.

CHILDREN'S WEAR



Party dress

Darker overcoat

Girls at this time were dressed as miniature versions of their mothers, with full dresses worn over two or more layers of petticoats to create a bell-shaped skirt. Young girls' skirts were shorter, however, and revealed pantalettes (linen or cotton leggings tied above the knee), which were edged with lace or pretty embroidery. When outdoors, these light-coloured dresses were covered with darker overcoats made from heavier fabrics. Bonnets and gloves were also worn.

Young boys also wore dresses until they were "breeched" (first dressed in breeches or trousers), which was usually when they were between four and eight years old.

Contrast trim Dark plum silk trimming draws attention to the fashionably small waist of this bodice and the fullness of the skirt, which is organ-pleated into the waistband.

1847

Ermine muff

Skirt made from two contrasting tiers

Long fitted sleeves

Dark plum trimming

Feather trim

Ringlets framed by bonnet

Slender waist, curving down at the front

Wide-brimmed bonnet shows curls

Frills add fullness to upper sleeve

Bell-shaped skirt worn over layers of petticoats

Soft silk and wool (challis) shawl with floral print

Pastel shades This summer dress in a lightweight fabric is trimmed with pretty frills. It is worn with a pastel yellow sash with matching ribbon and feather trimmings on the bonnet.

Silk bonnet with ribbon ties

Removable muslin collar

Striped shot taffeta This French dress has three flounces with pinked edges, which add volume to the skirt. It is trimmed at the neck and cuffs with white lace or embroidered linen.